

for the once-in-a-lifetime days

The Words Are the Gift

Six slides, five minutes · 826 spoken words at 165 a minute · timings are cumulative · the appendix is extra, not part of the five · the lines in the margin rule are directions, not spoken

SLIDE 01

Opening

0:00 — 0:40

| *Hold up a blank card, or just your empty hands.*

Last winter I stood in a stationery shop for twenty minutes, holding a birthday card for my grandmother.

The front was beautiful — gold foil, pressed flowers. The inside was blank, and I could not write a single word.

I knew exactly what I wanted to say. Every winter she taught me to make kimchi in her kitchen, laughing at the red pepper on my face. She kept a candy in her coat pocket, just for me. I knew all of that — I just could not get it onto the page.

So I wrote *Happy Birthday, stay healthy.* And I mailed it.

| *Pause.*

That card is the problem I have been working on.

SLIDE 02

The problem

0:40 — 1:25

The card industry has solved the outside completely. Foil, letterpress, a thousand designs for every occasion.

Nobody has solved the inside. The inside is still a blank rectangle and a pen.

And that blank rectangle is where the gift actually lives. Nobody keeps a card because the foil was nice. They keep it for what was written there.

So people do one of two things. They write four safe words, the way I did. Or they buy the card with the message already printed inside — a stranger's words, pretending to be yours.

Beat.

The hard part was never the design. It is that you have to be a writer at nine at night, in a shop, about someone you love.

SLIDE 03

The idea

1:25 — 2:15

So I built a studio for the inside of the card.

You tell it about the person, in your own messy words. It gives you back three things.

A letter, written from your details, not from a template. A card design built to match what the letter turned out to be about. And a cake topper — cut lettering on a stick, because in Korea the topper is in every photograph from that day.

The three are one object, not three products. The same story decides the words, the colours and the lettering — a quiet, grateful letter does not arrive on a card covered in confetti.

The studio is a small brand I am building around once-in-a-lifetime days — an old Korean word meaning *day after day*, the ordinary days you end up keeping.

ON SCREEN

Walkthrough

2:15 — 3:10

Switch to the studio. Click through the steps as you talk — do not read the screen aloud, let it move behind you.

It asks six short questions, one screen at a time — the first version was one long form, and nobody finished it.

Who is it for. A name, and how you know them. It sets how formal the letter is — in Korean, the whole level of speech.

What are we celebrating. Sixteen occasions, and not only the Western ones — a first birthday, a sixtieth, opening day for a shop, coming home from military service.

The story. The only screen that takes real effort. A memory, an inside joke, the thing you wish you could say.

The look. Minimal, vintage, watercolour — or let the studio decide.

Press the button. Let it run.

And then it writes — the card first, then the letter, a line at a time.

Read two or three lines of the letter aloud — not the whole thing.

Those details came out of four sentences I typed. It did not invent a grandmother; it used mine.

The last screen takes an address and opens your mail app with the order written out.

SLIDE 04

In wood

3:10 — 3:40

Back to the slides. Hold up the wooden piece if you have one.

The card is paper, and paper ends up in a drawer. So the message also goes into wood.

One oval stamp carries the whole thing — the greeting, the date, the signature — so every card and envelope that day is marked by the same hand.

And the same lines, split across stacked slats, become something you hang in the room where it happened. The message stops being a card and becomes the object.

Beat.

This is a first draft, in maple. It is the piece I most want to get right.

SLIDE 05

How it works

3:40 — 4:25

One thing under the hood is worth a minute, because the whole project rests on it.

The model never draws anything. It only decides.

It sends back a small block of structured data — a motif, four hex colours, a typeface, a finish. Then the browser draws the card and the topper from those numbers, live, on a canvas.

Beat.

That split buys three things. The output is always on brand, because the shapes are mine and only the choices are the model's. Redrawing is instant and free. And what comes out is a specification, not a picture — exact hex values and dimensions, what a print shop needs.

And if you want a photograph instead, the page writes the image prompt for you.

Close

4:25 — 5:00

What is next is the boring, real part. A maker for the wood pieces, a price for the set, and ten strangers who are not my friends.

| *Look up. Slower here.*

I am not trying to replace the person writing the card. What it gives you is a first draft — you are supposed to change it, because you were the one in that kitchen.

I just did not want anyone else to stand in a shop for twenty minutes and mail **stay healthy** to someone they love.

Thank you.

APPENDIX

Arakawa & Co., Ltd.

+ 0:35

| *Only if the hanging system comes up — the keepsake, or the room. Not part of the five minutes.*

Arakawa & Co., Ltd. is a Japanese hardware company founded in 1973 that developed the world's first toolless wire cable gripper system.

Their precision engineering allows thin wire cables to safely support heavy loads of up to 150 kg. Featuring a minimalist design that reduces visual noise, it has become the global standard for major museums and retail stores.

Today, they lead the global display market by providing high-quality hardware for art hanging, shopfitting, and architectural lighting. This innovative solution is highly trusted by architects and designers worldwide to maximize spatial aesthetics.